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Bus driver was cited weeks before fatal crash

Fined for failing to obey signals in New Jersey

By Laura Crimaldi
GLOBE STAFF

Weeks before a fatal bus collision in Virginia killed five Massachusetts residents, the bus driver was cited by New Jersey State Police for failing to obey traffic signals, records show.

The New Jersey violation, which hadn't been previously reported, offers a more complete picture of Jing Sheng Dong's commercial driving record leading up to the tragic crash a week ago on Interstate 95.

Since obtaining a commercial driver's license in 2024, Dong, 48, has been cited for speeding while driving buses in Maryland and Virginia and accused of misdemeanor trespassing at a truck stop in Virginia, records show.

In the New Jersey matter, Dong paid \$140 on May 9 to settle a citation for failing to obey signal signs or directions. He was ticketed on Route 33 in Robbinsville, N.J., near Trenton, online court records show. The records don't specify what kind of vehicle Dong was driving, and New Jersey State Police, which issued the citation, didn't respond Friday to a request for comment.

Since the fatal crash in Virginia, federal transportation officials have publicly feuded with the New York state licensing agency over granting Dong a commercial driving credential.

Last week, US Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said in a social media post that

DRIVER, Page A6

Mass. limits insurers' use of prior authorization

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Dr. Debra Shapiro and her staff spend hours in their Cambridge practice each week asking permission from insurers to prescribe their primary care patients certain medications and procedures.

The arduous process, known as prior authorization, eats up their time and delays care for Shaprio's patients experiencing pressing ailments like chest pain, intestinal infections, and even cancer.

But on Friday, the Healey administration took steps to ease those headaches, issuing rules that limit when insurers can require prior authorization for prescriptions and tests, along with visits to certain providers.

The regulations are meant to restrict the red tape surrounding some essential services and medications for managing chronic diseases, including diabetes and asthma. They also establish protections for patients who switch insurance providers. And they ban prior authorizations for physical, occupational, and speech therapies, maternity services, and medications for serious mental illness, among other changes.

The decision over which services and medications to exempt from prior authorizations were determined following hearings with stake-

AUTHORIZATION, Page A5

At Bunker Hill, an edit to history

US orders quotes about slaves, immigrants, war removed from banners at monument

By Tonya Alanez
and Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

and Lauren Albano
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The National Park Service has ordered three quotes removed from banners at the Bunker Hill Monument that comment on American slavery, the contributions of immigrants, and the purpose of war me-

morials.

The quotes hang in the Bunker Hill Lodge, which serves as an entrance to the 221-foot-high monument, and flank a statue of patriot leader Joseph Warren, who was killed June 17, 1775, in the first large-scale battle of the Revolution.

Staff for US Senator Edward J. Markey confirmed the quotes are due to be removed. At the park on

Friday, National Park Service rangers declined to comment on when the quotes would be taken down.

The planned removal, first reported by The Washington Post, marks another move by federal officials to erase interpretive language at national parks and elsewhere that speaks to diversity, equity, and inclusion.

Some preservationists equated the move with government censorship.

"Censoring the contributions of any people that came before us

would go against the very ideals that were fought for at this place," said Kristen Sykes, Northeast regional director of the National Parks Conservation Association, an advocacy group. "Our national parks belong to all of us. Visitors deserve the chance to learn our struggles and triumphs alike, free of government censorship."

The targeted quotes include one from a 19th-century abolitionist who mocked the existence of American slavery 70 years after the battle. An-

BUNKER HILL, Page A10



PHOTOS BY CHRISTIAN KANTOSKY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE



NURTURING A NATURE TRAIL

Guides were released this week for a new hiking path, Boston Boundless Trail, that runs through the city and 13 surrounding communities. The walking trail network uses "green spaces, built environments, and walkable connections between them," said Miles Howard, director of Walking City Trails. The Quincy Quarries Reservation is part of the pathway. **B1.**

Municipal deficits grow and layoffs loom

Override losses, inflation force cuts ahead of fiscal year

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

Malden is slated to lay off 29 public employees, including five firefighters. In Somerville, a clinical youth specialist was among the 13 abruptly axed. And in New Bedford, where the exasperated mayor said the financial strife had "reached a boiling point,"

the cuts reach deep into the police department ledger with the planned elimination of two dozen vacant positions, all while another 36 employees in city departments are set to be let go and a fire station is on the chopping block.

Across Massachusetts, communities are confronting what some describe as the most intractable budget shortfalls in decades. Exact numbers of people losing their jobs may vary as labor negotiations play out, but the budgets city leaders are putting forward this year have called for a flurry

of program cuts and pink slips in these last weeks before the new fiscal year that begins next month.

"We are going to start to see cuts and layoffs that we haven't seen probably since 2008 and 2009 during the Great Recession," said Adam Chapdelaine, executive director of the Massachusetts Municipal Association, a nonprofit that advocates for local officials.

The organization had forewarned of what was coming as far back as October when it issued a report it called

LAYOFFS, Page A6

The chairman of the Needham Parks and Recreation Commission was arrested on federal charges that he allegedly drained a Little League team's bank account of \$250,000. **B1.**

In the year before the Croft School's financial collapse, founder Scott Given used school funds to reimburse himself and his family close to \$800,000, according to the private school's bankruptcy filing. **D1.**



Maybe boomers

Saturday: Afternoon storm. High: 83-88. Low: 67-72.

Sunday: Cloudy, showers. High: 80-85. Low: 56-61.

Sunrise: 5:08 Sunset: 8:18 Comics and Weather, **D4-5.** Obituaries, **C9.**

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Rainy days on Saturdays are getting us down

It's been 5 weeks since Boston's had a dry weekend

By Ken Mahan
GLOBE STAFF

Yes, in fact, it does rain on your day off. I've heard your cries, and honestly, I'm over it, too.

Since the turn of March, the start of meteorological spring over three months ago, Boston, Providence, and most of Southern New England haven't had a weekend in which temperatures were normal and the ground stayed dry. In fact, of the past 14 weekends, a full dozen of them had rain at some point in parts of Southern New England. The other two weekends were dry but colder than normal.

That's 14 straight weeks of having to adjust weekend plans. And this weekend will mark 15 (and the 13th with rain).

In Greater Boston, we haven't seen a completely dry weekend in five weeks, since the end of April. And during that weekend of April 25-26, temperatures were more than 5 degrees colder than average.

Now we haven't had quite the record-setting streak such as we saw last year, when Saturdays were renamed "Soggyday" after a record 13 straight weeks with measurable rain. But nonetheless, it doesn't make this latest wet weekend pattern any easier to live with.

I'd like to emphasize that few would care if this stretch happened on Monday and Tuesday. But with beautiful weekdays followed by gloomy weekends — wow, this pattern gets old.

So what's the deal?

We typically see a more active jet stream

RAIN, Page A10



LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

Since the turn of March, Boston, Providence, and most of Southern New England haven't had a weekend in which temperatures were normal and the ground stayed dry.